



BEFORE

Afghanistan is ethnically diverse, with a rugged geography. Dogged by clan and tribal issues, it has repeatedly been invaded.

A LANDLOCKED COUNTRY

Afghanistan lies at the **heart of Asia**, nestled between Iran in the west and Pakistan in the south and east. Its northern borders touch former Soviet countries such as Uzbekistan.

STABILITY AND UNREST

Between 1933–73, Afghanistan was stable under King Sahir Shah. In 1973, a **bloodless coup** saw his brother-in-law, Sardar Daoud Khan (below), seize control of the country. He was murdered in 1978 when the communist **People's Democratic Party of Afghanistan (PDPA)** launched the Great Saur Revolution.



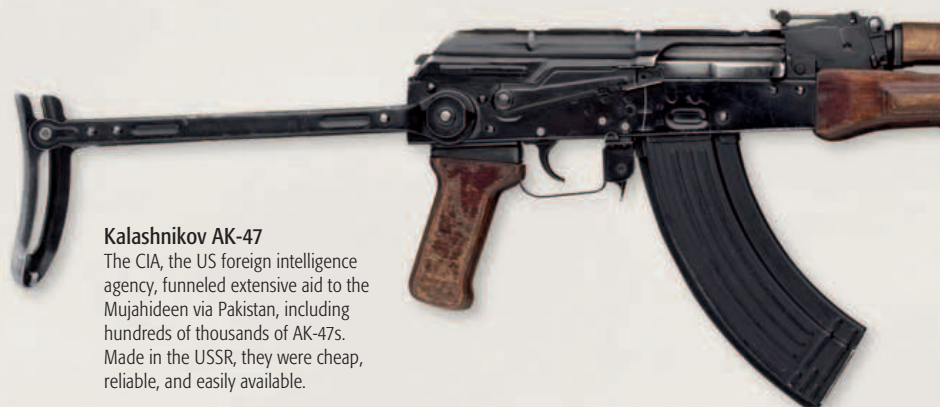
PRIME MINISTER
SARDAR DAOUD KHAN

COMMUNIST
TAKEOVER

Supported by the USSR, the PDPA applied Marxist-style reforms **◀ 334–35**, such as state control of agriculture. In 1978, a treaty was signed allowing the use of Soviet troops if requested by Afghanistan.

When the People's Democratic Party of Afghanistan (PDPA) took power in 1978 (see BEFORE), conflict broke out immediately. After several days of internal power struggles, a party leader and Marxist scholar, Noor Mohammed Tureki, became the President of Afghanistan. There were primarily two Marxist groups in the country: the Khalq Party and the Parcham Party. Tureki was the leader of the former. To establish a communist government in Afghanistan, the Khalq and the Parcham parties agreed to split power, but only a few months later Tureki killed and jailed many Parchamis and pressed ahead with a rapid program of communist reform, including secularism, equal rights for women, and land redistribution; but within months insurrection was breaking out all over the country. In March 1979, a resistance group declared a *jihad*, or "holy war," against the godless regime

- 1 MILLION** Afghans died in the war.
- 5 MILLION** Afghans became refugees in nearby countries.
- 52 THOUSAND** Soviet soldiers were killed or wounded.



Kalashnikov AK-47

The CIA, the US foreign intelligence agency, funneled extensive aid to the Mujahideen via Pakistan, including hundreds of thousands of AK-47s. Made in the USSR, they were cheap, reliable, and easily available.

in Kabul. In the same month more than 100 Soviet citizens were killed in Herat, western Afghanistan. In September 1979, Tureki tried to assassinate his prime minister, Hafizulla Amin. Amin had Tureki arrested, and took control of the government. He later announced that Tureki was dead.

American involvement

The United States had been keeping a careful eye on the new Soviet-backed regime. In the 1950s and 1960s, four US presidents faced the significant task of defending American interests in the Middle East and South Asia, particularly in the vast reservoirs of oil and natural gas in and around the Persian Gulf and the Arabian Peninsula. With the onset of

the Cold War in 1946 (see pp.406–07), the US perceived the Soviet Union to be their main threat. This perception was to continue for the next half-century. The US sought advice from politicians in anticommunist Muslim

Fighting back

From machine gun nests like this one above the Jagdalak Valley, insurgents attack Soviet forces, who were vulnerable in the mountainous terrain.



War in Afghanistan

When Soviet armed forces invaded neighboring Afghanistan in December 1979, they were supremely confident of seizing immediate control. However, the Russian troops found themselves bogged down in a ten-year war that proved to be a disaster for both countries. The war hastened the breakup of the Soviet Union, and plunged Afghanistan into a state of lawlessness.

